



THE YOUTH REVOLUTION

This iconic image from the film *The Wild One* (1953) turned the brooding Marlon Brando into a poster boy for young people feeding off post-war restlessness and aching to escape the polite conventions of 1950s society. His blue denim jeans and zipped black leather jacket would become universal leisurewear. In the film, Brando plays the leader of a motorbike gang. When asked what he's rebelling against, he drawls, "Whaddya got?". The film caused a scandal.

Two years later James Dean, playing a troubled young man in *Rebel Without a Cause* (1955), created a similar look – blue jeans, white T-shirt, boots, and a leather or windcheater jacket (including the red Harrington windcheater in *Rebel*) – that continues across the decades. Such looks were subversive not just because they were associated with "working" clothes or hoodlums, but because they were social levellers – these were styles worn by film stars that most people could afford.

Brando became an identity-marker for the teenager – a notion that had barely existed pre-war – and for teenage fashions. Increased 1950s prosperity, and the rise of advertising and mass consumerism, helped to celebrate youth while also giving teenagers something to rebel against.

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He pulled on his big leather motorcycling jacket and went out to his bike. They met at a café called Nick's. It was a working men's café in the daytime, quite ordinary, but at night it was different. It acquired for them at least an excitement and glamour.

GILLIAN FREEMAN, *THE LEATHER BOYS*, 1961

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◀ A REBEL WITH MANY CAUSES

Seminal youth-culture film *The Wild One* (1953), starring Marlon Brando, spawned many biker movies and biker-influenced looks.